Preface

This little book was written for the ChessBox Informant project. It retells three famous pieces of chess history in plain words, so that the indexer has something honest to read. The games and the study are more than a century old and belong to everyone; the commentary is our own.

Nothing here is meant to be the last word on these positions. The notes try to explain why the moves work, the way a friend would explain them over a board, rather than list every possible defence.

Read the moves slowly and play them out. A position you have set up with your own hands is a position you remember.

Chapter 1: The Opera Game

Paul Morphy against the Duke of Brunswick and Count Isouard, consulting together, Paris 1858. The game was played in a box at the opera, and Morphy, the story goes, kept glancing at the stage. His opponents did not get much of his attention, and they did not need much.

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.d4 Bg4?! The Philidor Defence, with a pin that gives away too much. Black wants to hold the centre, but the bishop will soon have to give itself up for the knight.

4.dxe5 Bxf3 More or less forced. (4...dxe5 5.Qxd8+ Kxd8 6.Nxe5 leaves Black a pawn down, without the right to castle, and with the bishop on g4 attacked as well.)

5.Qxf3 dxe5 6.Bc4 Nf6 7.Qb3 Two attacks at once, on f7 and on b7. Black can cover only one of them comfortably.

7...Qe7 Black guards f7 and leaves b7 to its fate, but Morphy has bigger plans than a pawn.

(8.Qxb7 Qb4+ 9.Qxb4 Bxb4+ 10.c3 wins a pawn, but the trade of queens would take the life out of the attack.)

8.Nc3 c6 9.Bg5 b5? Black tries to chase the bishop from c4, but the pawn on b5 is a target, not a shield.

10.Nxb5! cxb5 11.Bxb5+ Nbd7 12.O-O-O Every white piece now joins the attack, and the pin on the d-file decides the game. (12.O-O Rd8 is also good for White, but castling long brings the rook to the d-file at once.)

12...Rd8 13.Rxd7! Rxd7 14.Rd1 Qe6 15.Bxd7+ Nxd7 16.Qb8+!! The queen is offered so that the last rook can come in. 16...Nxb8 17.Rd8# 1-0

Morphy gave up a knight, a rook, a bishop and finally his queen, and he won with the two pieces he had left. Notice how little his pawns did: after the fourth move none of them moved again.

Players often ask whether games this old are still worth studying, now that opening theory has moved on. This one answers the question by itself.

Quick development, open lines and the pin have not aged at all; only the defenders have learned to be more careful.

Chapter 2: The Immortal Game

Adolf Anderssen against Lionel Kieseritzky, London 1851, a casual game played between rounds of the first international tournament. Neither player cared much about material, and the result is one of the most quoted games ever played.

1.e4 e5 2.f4 The King's Gambit, the fashion of the day. 2...exf4 3.Bc4 Qh4+ 4.Kf1 White can no longer castle, but the black queen has come out early and will be chased.

4...b5?! Black returns the pawn at once to pull the bishop away from c4. 5.Bxb5 Nf6 6.Nf3 Qh6 7.d3 Nh5 8.Nh4 Qg5 9.Nf5 c6 10.g4 Nf6

11.Rg1!? Anderssen leaves the bishop on b5 to its fate and brings the rook behind the advancing pawns instead. 11...cxb5 12.h4 Qg6 13.h5 Qg5 14.Qf3 Ng8

Black's knight has gone back home. White's queen, rook and knight are all in play, while Black

has developed only the queen, and she keeps running out of squares.

15.Bxf4 Qf6 16.Nc3 Bc5 17.Nd5 Qxb2 18.Bd6!! The bishop offers both white rooks. Black may take them, but the white minor pieces will build a mating net around the black king long before the extra material matters.

18...Bxg1 19.e5 Qxa1+ 20.Ke2 Na6 21.Nxg7+ Kd8 22.Qf6+ Nxf6 23.Be7# 1-0

At the end White had given away both rooks, a bishop and the queen. Three minor pieces were enough, because every one of them stood on a square that mattered.

Chapter 3: Saavedra's Study

This study grew out of a position published in 1895. Fernando Saavedra found the winning idea, and it has been in every collection since.

White: king on b6, pawn on c6. Black: king on a1, rook on d5. White to play and win.

1.c7 Rd6+ 2.Kb5 Rd5+ 3.Kb4 Rd4+ 4.Kb3 Rd3+ 5.Kc2 The king has walked down the board and attacks the rook, so the checks are over.

5...Rd4! A clever reply. If the pawn now becomes a queen, Black has a stalemate trick ready. (6.c8=Q?? Rc4+ 7.Qxc4 and Black, with no legal move, is stalemated.)

6.c8=R! A rook is enough, and it cannot be given up for stalemate. White threatens mate on the a-file. 6...Ra4 7.Kb3 Now the black rook is attacked and mate on c1 is threatened at the same time. White wins.

Chapter 4: On Pawn Structure

The three examples in this book are all about piece play, but behind each of them is a pawn structure that made the pieces strong. In the Opera Game, Black's slow opening left the diagonal from c4 to f7 open, and every white piece used it.

A pawn cannot move backwards. Every pawn move gives up control of some squares for good, and a strong player asks which squares a move will weaken before playing it. When a square such as d5 can no longer be attacked by an enemy pawn, it becomes a home for a knight.

This is why so many quiet positions are decided by a single pawn move made twenty moves earlier. The pieces come and go, but the pawns stay, and they tell you where the pieces belong.